

CLICKING WITH THE YOUTH
CM Pushkar Singh Dhami poses for a selfie during an event held in Dehradun honouring meritorious girl students of Uttarakhand, Oct. 11, 2021

WITH THE BJP TRYING TO WOO UTTARAKHAND'S YOUTH, HAVING 46-YEAR-OLD DHAMI, YOUNGEST IN THE CABINET, AT THE HELM SUITS THE PARTY WELL

dizzying bout of roulette—the central leadership dumped Trivendra Rawat and then Tirath Singh Rawat within four months, leaving him with a less-than-pretty administrative legacy. He also found himself at the helm of a greying cabinet: Dhami himself was its youngest and juniormost member. Cannily enough, he and his party have doubled down on that theme. This is just as well, because Uttarakhand's 79.4 lakh-strong electorate has around 12 lakh new voters. The narrative on this front suits the BJP: the Congress's CM aspirant, Harish Rawat, is 73; the next in line, Pritam Singh, is 63. The BJP has fielded 22 new faces, 14 of them younger than Dhami.

The youth focus addresses a key pain point for the BJP regime. Two months after Dhami took over, NSO data for October-December 2020 showed that 27 per cent of Uttarakhand in the 15-29 age bracket were jobless (higher than the national average of 25 per cent). The graph had peaked at 38 per cent during the lockdown, and never receded to the pre-Covid 21 per cent. Also, 500,000 natives migrated back to the state during this period, their life in the metros disrupted by the pandemic. Worst of all, neither regular industry in the slender patch of low-lands in southern Uttarakhand nor the tourism and hospitality segment in the hills have recovered from the massive hit they took. All that marks out a perennial theme in these parts in red highlighter ink. "Uttarakhand's youth has been plagued by unemployment for long now," admits Jay Singh Rawat, a Dehradun-based political analyst.

Dhami's problem is that he has nothing much to show right now except promises. On December 30, the PM had laid the foundation stones for 23 projects worth over Rs 17,500 crore. On the anvil are multiple road-widening projects, a hydropower project in Dhami's own homestead of Pithoragarh in the far east, and a sewerage network upgradation in Nainital. All this sounds more productive than the Rs 5,000 monthly dole AAP's Arvind Kejriwal is promising, but it is all work in progress—to use the optimistic phrase—and will take time to bear fruit in terms of real jobs. That's why one of Dhami's aides calls attention to a 'dual' strategy: "In order to pull up the BJP's prospects, Dhami has to streamline stuck projects to generate jobs, and also appeal to the emotions of his voters."

This is where Hindutva and nationalism come in—Uttarakhand, which hosts some of Hinduism's holiest pilgrimage sites and sends droves of youth to the armed forces, is particularly receptive to that line of politics. But Hindutva can be a complex game to play here. The temples, seers and akharas operate at a level of conservatism often vastly deeper than that of the BJP-RSS—and have a fiercely autonomous streak to boot. None of the BJP's CMs can hope to exert any influence on them. In fact, Modi had to intervene and convince the akharas to scale down Kumbh celebrations at Haridwar last year. Trivendra Singh Rawat, an old RSS hand, prised open a faultline there during his stint as CM with a legislation that sought to take over administrative control of the Char Dham—Kedarnath, Badrinath, Gangotri and Yamunotri—besides 49 other temples. The howls of protests started from the seers, spread to the VHP and Trivendra's old buddies in the RSS, and inevitably reached the assembly halls. Recently, the Dhami regime, too, had to risk the wrath of the saffron-robed ones when, on instructions from the PMO, he finally cracked down on hate speeches at the Haridwar dharam sansad.

There's another perennial faultline in Uttarakhand: the emotional divide between the two hill divisions of Garhwal and Kumaon. Here too, Trivendra had stirred a hornet's nest by notifying Gairsain as a third hill division, with districts from both Garhwal and Kumaon—the latter would have had to cede even its cultural capital, Almora! In the end, along with his ill-fated temple bill, this ensured he was practically escorted out of office with black flags. While the ex-CM has plenty time to repent at leisure, the BJP is hoping the relatively young Dhami can wind the clock forward. His real hope may lie in the fact that the Congress, otherwise well-placed for a pendulum swing, is excellent at the art of fratricide. ■